Windows Notepad

User Guide

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1. Overview

Windows Notepad is a lightweight text editor included with Windows. You can use Notepad to create, view, and edit plain-text files without the formatting and layout features provided by word-processing applications.

Notepad is suitable for simple tasks such as creating notes, editing configuration files, viewing logs, and making quick changes to source code or markup files. Recent versions of Notepad in Windows 11 also provide features such as tabs, dark mode, find and replace, and automatic session restoration.

Notepad works with text content rather than application-specific document formats. As a result, it can edit many files that contain text, but it does not provide specialized features such as syntax highlighting, code completion, or validation for programming and data formats.

Important: *A file extension does not determine whether a file is suitable for editing in Notepad. Before saving a file, make sure that the file contains text and that the application that uses the file supports manual text editing.*

2. Basic User Scenarios

Scenario	Description	Primary benefit
Create a text file	Create a new document to record notes, lists, or other plain-text information.	Provides a simple environment for entering text.
Edit a text file	Open an existing .txt file and modify its contents.	Provides a quick way to make basic text changes.
Edit a configuration file	Open a text-based configuration file, such as .ini, .json, or .xml, and modify its contents.	Allows users to make configuration changes without a specialized editor.
View a log file	Open a .log file to review application or system messages.	Provides a quick way to inspect text-based logs.
Edit source code or markup	Open a text-based file, such as .html, .css, .js, or .py, and make basic changes.	Allows quick edits without installing a dedicated code editor.
Clean plain text	Paste text into Notepad to remove most rich-text formatting before copying it to another application.	Provides a simple way to work with unformatted text.

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3. File Compatibility, Limitations, and Technical Specifics

3.1 Files you can edit as text

Notepad can be used to edit files that store their content as text. The file extension does not by itself determine whether Notepad can open the file. You can select **All Files (.)** when opening a file to browse for extensions other than .txt.

Common examples include:

- **Text and log files:** .txt, .log
- **Data and configuration files:** .csv, .json, .xml, .ini, .cfg, .yaml, .yml, .env
- **Source code and markup:** .html, .css, .js, .py, .java, .cpp, .sql, .bat, .ps1, .md

Notepad does not interpret these formats. For example, when you open a JSON file, Notepad displays the JSON as text. It does not validate the JSON or provide JSON-specific editing features.

3.2 Text encoding

Text files can use different character encodings. The encoding determines how characters are represented in the file.

Modern versions of Notepad support common Unicode encodings, including UTF-8 and UTF-16. When you open or save a file, use the encoding required by the application that consumes the file.

Using an incompatible encoding can cause characters to display incorrectly or change when the file is saved. For files that contain non-ASCII characters, verify the encoding before saving changes.

3.3 Limitations

Consider the following limitations before using Notepad to edit a file:

- **Binary files:** Do not edit binary files such as .exe, .dll, .png, .jpg, or application-specific document files in Notepad. The displayed content might be unreadable, and saving the file can damage its original format.
- **No syntax validation:** Notepad does not validate JSON, XML, HTML, or programming-language syntax. A typing error can make a file invalid or prevent the application that uses it from working correctly.

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- **No code-editor features:** Notepad does not provide features such as syntax highlighting, code completion, debugging, or integrated development tools.
- **Large files:** Very large text files can take longer to open and edit and might affect application responsiveness.
- **Plain-text formatting:** Notepad does not provide word-processing features such as bold, italics, tables, or embedded images as part of the file's plain-text content.

Best practice: Create a backup before editing an important configuration, script, or data file. After saving the file, verify that the application that uses the file can still read it correctly.

4. Procedure

4.1 Open an HTML File as Text

By default, double-clicking an HTML file, such as index.html, opens it in the default web browser. The browser renders the HTML as a webpage. To view or edit the HTML source code, open the file in Notepad.

Prerequisites

- A Windows 10 or Windows 11 computer.
- An existing HTML file, such as index.html, stored on your computer.
- Permission to modify the file if you want to save changes.

Steps

1. Press the **Windows** key, type **Notepad**, and select **Notepad** from the search results. You can also press **Windows + R**, type **notepad**, and select **OK**.
2. In Notepad, select **File > Open** or press **Ctrl + O**.
3. In the **Open** dialog box, select the file-type filter and change **Text Documents (*.txt)** to **All Files (.)**.

   Note: If the file-type filter set to Text Documents (*.txt), files with extensions like .html or .json will be hidden.
4. Browse to the folder that contains the HTML file, select the file, and select **Open**.
5. Select the **Encoding** that matches the file. **UTF-8** is commonly used for HTML files or select **Auto-Detect**.

   Note: Using the wrong encoding can cause characters to display incorrectly.

6. Verify that the HTML source code is displayed as text. For example:

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<body>
  <h1>Welcome</h1>
</body>
</html>
```

7. Edit the HTML source code as required. Preserve the HTML syntax, including quotation marks, angle brackets, and opening and closing tags.
8. Press **Ctrl + S** or select **File > Save** to save the changes.
9. Open the HTML file in a web browser to verify that the changes produce the expected webpage.

Note: Notepad is a text editor. It does not validate HTML syntax or provide HTML-specific editing features. An invalid change can cause the webpage to display incorrectly.

4.2 Alternative method to open an HTML file

You can open the file directly from **File Explorer**.

1. Right-click the HTML file.
2. Select **Open with**, and then select **Notepad**.

The **Open with** option lets you choose an application other than the default application associated with the file type.

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